Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology
PUBLISHED BY THE INSTITUTE FOR MEANING-CENTERED PSYCHOLOGY

Volume 1 · Issue 3 · October 2026
pp. 76–79 · Open access · CC BY 4.0

THEORETICAL ARTICLE

What Remains Human

Encounter, presence, and the existential dimension of psychotherapy in the age of artificial intelligence

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ABSTRACT

As conversational agents become increasingly capable of producing empathic-sounding language, the question of what is distinctively human in psychotherapy has gained practical urgency. This theoretical contribution approaches the question from the perspective of existential and meaning-centered psychology. Drawing on Viktor E. Frankl's logotherapy, Martin Buber's philosophy of dialogue, and Irvin D. Yalom's existential psychotherapy, we distinguish between functions of psychotherapy that software may partly support or simulate, such as information, structure, and reflective prompts, and dimensions that presuppose a person on both sides of the encounter. These include presence as being-with, the I–Thou relation, shared exposure to the ultimate concerns of death, freedom, isolation, and meaninglessness, and the responsible witnessing of another person's search for meaning. We relate these concepts to research on common factors and the therapeutic alliance and to reports that users experience bond-like relationships with chatbots. We argue that such experiences deserve to be taken seriously but should not be equated with encounter in the existential sense. The paper concludes that a meaning-centered perspective neither rejects digital tools nor idealizes them, but asks whether they serve a person's self-transcendence or substitute for it.

Keywords: encounter · therapeutic presence · existential psychotherapy · logotherapy · artificial intelligence

1 Introduction

When Joseph Weizenbaum (1966) presented ELIZA, a simple program that imitated a Rogerian therapist by reflecting users' statements, he was struck by how readily people attributed understanding to it. A decade later, he warned against delegating to computers tasks that require respect, care, and judgment (Weizenbaum, 1976). Today's large language models produce language that is far more flexible than ELIZA's templates, and they are trained on vast amounts of human text, including text about suffering and consolation (Bender et al., 2021). The old question has therefore returned in a new form: if software can say what a therapist might say, what, if anything, remains specifically human in psychotherapy?

This paper approaches the question from the perspective of existential and meaning-centered psychology. It does not aim to predict technical developments or to assess particular applications. Instead, it seeks conceptual clarity about which dimensions of psychotherapy depend on the presence of a person and why these dimensions matter. We draw on Frankl's logotherapy, Buber's philosophy of dialogue, and Yalom's existential psychotherapy, and relate them to empirical research on the therapeutic relationship.

2 Common Factors and the Limits of Functional Description

Psychotherapy research has shown that a substantial portion of treatment outcome is associated with factors common to different approaches, among them the therapeutic relationship (Wampold & Imel, 2015). Bordin (1979) described the working alliance as consisting of agreement on goals, agreement on tasks, and an affective bond, and meta-analytic work has reported a robust association between alliance and outcome (Flückiger et al., 2018). Earlier, Rogers (1957) had proposed empathy, unconditional positive regard, and genuineness as central conditions of therapeutic change.

These findings can be read in two ways. A functional reading suggests that if the relevant factors can be described as behaviors, they can in principle be reproduced by any system that displays these behaviors. Indeed, users of a chatbot have reported experiences that resemble a bond on standard alliance measures (Darcy et al., 2021). An existential reading, by contrast, holds that empathy, regard, and genuineness are not merely observable behaviors but qualities of a relationship between two persons. Genuineness, in particular, presupposes that someone is there who could also be otherwise. The question is therefore not whether software can generate empathic sentences, which it evidently can, but whether the meaning of such sentences changes when no one stands behind them.

3 Encounter: Buber's I–Thou Relation

Buber (1923/1970) distinguished two basic attitudes in which human beings relate to the world. In the I–It relation, the other is experienced as an object that can be described, used, and classified. In the I–Thou relation, the other is met as a whole, in mutuality and presence, without being reduced to properties. For Buber, the I–Thou relation cannot be produced methodically; it happens as encounter, and it cannot be held permanently, since every Thou must again become an It.

Applied to psychotherapy, this distinction clarifies something that functional models tend to overlook. Much of what therapists do legitimately belongs to the I–It mode: diagnosis, case formulation, the planning of interventions. Yet patients often describe decisive moments of therapy as moments in which they felt met as persons rather than processed as cases. Buber's concept of mutuality is demanding here: encounter requires that both parties are present as someone. A language model can respond to a user, but in Buber's sense it does not meet anyone, because there is no one who could be addressed in return. Users may nonetheless experience the exchange as personal, and this experience is psychologically real. What is lacking is not the user's experience but the reciprocity that would make it an encounter.

Turkle (2011) described how people increasingly accept the performance of relationship by machines as sufficient and how this acceptance may change expectations of human relationships. From a dialogical perspective, the concern is not that people find comfort in such exchanges, but that the difference between being responded to and being met could become less visible.

4 Presence and the Ultimate Concerns

Therapeutic presence has been described as a state in which the therapist is fully in the moment with the client, receptive, grounded, and responsive (Geller & Greenberg, 2012). Presence in this sense involves the therapist's body, attention, and vulnerability. It is not a technique applied to the client but a way of being with the client, and clients may perceive it as the experience that someone is truly there.

Yalom (1980) identified four ultimate concerns that shape human existence and often underlie psychological suffering: death, freedom, existential isolation, and meaninglessness. These concerns are not problems that a therapist solves for a patient; they are conditions that therapist and patient share. When a patient speaks about mortality or fundamental aloneness, the therapist is not a neutral observer but a fellow human being who is exposed to the same conditions. In Yalom's account, therapists are not exempt from these concerns, and their own confrontation with them shapes how they accompany others.

Software does not share this condition. A language model does not die, does not choose, and is not isolated in the existential sense. It can generate reflections on finitude, but it does not face finitude. This is not a deficiency in performance that better models could remedy; it is a categorical difference. For many therapeutic tasks this difference may be irrelevant. For conversations that touch the ultimate concerns, it may be decisive.

5 Meaning, Responsibility, and Self-Transcendence

Frankl (1946/1985) placed the will to meaning at the center of human motivation and described meaning as something that cannot be given but must be found by the person in the concrete situation. Logotherapy understands the human being as responsible, as one who answers the questions that life poses (Frankl, 1969). Meaning is realized through self-transcendence, that is, by being directed toward something or someone other than oneself, whether a task, a value, or another person.

From this perspective, a risk of AI in psychotherapy lies less in errors than in convenience. A system that responds instantly, never tires, and readily validates may meet needs for attention without asking anything in return. Frankl (1946/1985) described the existential vacuum as a state of inner emptiness and boredom that people may try to cover over in various ways. A permanently available conversational partner

could serve such a function, offering relief without directing the person toward the world and others. Conversely, digital tools might support self-transcendence when they encourage patients to take steps toward relationships, tasks, and values outside the conversation.

In logotherapy, the therapist is not a provider of meaning either. Through Socratic dialogue, the therapist helps patients discover possibilities of meaning themselves. What the therapist contributes is less an answer than a stance: confidence in the patient's capacity for meaning and a willingness to witness the patient's struggle. Being witnessed by another person who could also look away is a different experience from being processed by a system that cannot.

6 Implications for a Meaning-Centered View of Digital Therapy

Three implications follow. First, the distinction between functions and dimensions offers a criterion for a division of labor. Information, structure, reminders, and exercises may be supported by software, whereas conversations about guilt, death, loss, and the question of meaning should remain anchored in human relationships. Second, the bond-like experiences that users report with chatbots should be taken seriously as expressions of genuine needs, but they should not be described in the same terms as encounter, since conceptual imprecision can mislead patients and policymakers alike (Fiske et al., 2019). Third, digital tools should be evaluated not only by symptom change but also by whether they lead people toward or away from others and toward or away from a responsible engagement with their lives.

These implications do not amount to a rejection of technology. A meaning-centered perspective asks of every tool whether it serves the person's self-transcendence or substitutes for it. The same question applies to human therapists, since therapy can also foster dependence or offer premature answers. The age of AI does not create the existential dimension of psychotherapy, but it makes this dimension more visible by contrast.

7 Conclusion

What remains human in psychotherapy is not primarily a set of skills, many of which can be described, trained, and partially simulated. It is the fact that a person meets another person, shares the fundamental conditions of existence with that person, and takes responsibility for being present. Buber's I–Thou relation, Yalom's ultimate concerns, and Frankl's understanding of meaning and responsibility each describe this dimension from a different angle. As AI becomes part of mental health care, the task is to protect this dimension without disregarding what technology can offer, so that patients may be helped by tools while still being met by persons.

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HOW TO CITE

Pazer, S., Whitcombe, E. M., & Ashford, S. R. (2026). What Remains Human: Encounter, presence, and the existential dimension of psychotherapy in the age of artificial intelligence. Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology, 1(3), 76–79.

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